



ATSA

AQUATIC TRAINING SOLUTIONS AUSTRALIA

A 100-DAY TEACHING CHALLENGE

THE 1% BETTER CHALLENGE

100 tiny changes. 100 days. A better teacher on the deck.

RAISING THE STANDARD IN AQUATIC EDUCATION

Aquatic Training Solutions Australia

THE IDEA

How this challenge works

You don't become a better teacher in one heroic leap. You become one by getting slightly better, on purpose, every day.

Each day for 100 days, make one small, deliberate change to how you teach — a name learned, an instruction shortened, a choice offered, a hazard cleared. On its own each change is barely noticeable. Stacked over 100 days, they compound into a genuinely different teacher on the pool deck.

A note on the maths. We call it '100 days to 100% better', but 1% better compounded over 100 days is actually about $2.7\times$ — almost three times better. We promised 100%; the maths quietly over-delivers.

USING THIS BOOKLET

- 1 Pick the day.** Work through in order, or dip into the theme you most want to grow.
- 2 Do the one thing.** Make that single change in your next lesson — nothing else required.
- 3 Tick it off.** Mark the day on the tracker and in its theme page.
- 4 Reflect each theme.** At the end of each ten-day theme, answer the reflection prompt.

Tip. Consistency beats intensity. A missed day isn't failure — just pick it up tomorrow. The habit is the point.

The 100-Day Tracker

Each row is a ten-day theme. Tick off a day as you complete it and watch the challenge fill in.

1	Connection & Rapport	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
2	Clear Communication	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
3	Inclusion & Neurodiversity	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30
4	Safety & Awareness	31	32	33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40
5	Feedback & Encouragement	41	42	43	44	45	46	47	48	49	50
6	Lesson Craft & Technique	51	52	53	54	55	56	57	58	59	60
7	The Environment	61	62	63	64	65	66	67	68	69	70
8	Parents & Families	71	72	73	74	75	76	77	78	79	80
9	Looking After Yourself	81	82	83	84	85	86	87	88	89	90
10	Leadership & Growth	91	92	93	94	95	96	97	98	99	100

Ten themes · ten days each · one hundred tiny changes

Connection & Rapport

Trust is the water everything else floats on. Before a learner will try, they need to feel seen and safe.

- 1 **Learn one new learner's name before they get in the water.** ☐
A child who hears their own name relaxes faster — the first signal they're seen, not processed.
- 2 **Get down to eye level for your first instruction every lesson.** ☐
Towering over a nervous child reads as threat; meeting their eye line reads as safety.
- 3 **Greet each learner by name as they arrive on the deck.** ☐
The lesson starts the moment they see you. A named hello sets the tone.
- 4 **Ask one learner about something outside swimming.** ☐
Two minutes of 'I see the whole you' buys ten minutes of trust in the water.
- 5 **Name one thing a learner did well before correcting anything.** ☐
Brains learn faster when they feel safe. Lead with the win.
- 6 **Use a learner's name in your praise, not just 'good job'.** ☐
'Good job' is wallpaper. 'Great reach, Mia' is a memory.
- 7 **Find the quiet child and give them a moment of full attention.** ☐
The loud ones get noticed by default. The quiet ones often hold the most.
- 8 **Smile at a parent on the way past and tell them one good thing.** ☐
A ten-second positive turns a sceptic into an ally.
- 9 **Ask about something a learner told you last week.** ☐
'How did the soccer game go?' tells a child you carry them between lessons.
- 10 **End every lesson with a specific, genuine sign-off.** ☐
How a lesson ends is what they carry home. Make the last twenty seconds count.

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Which learner did you connect with this week — and what changed once you did?

Clear Communication

A nervous child in the water has very little working memory to spare. Say less, show more, mean it.

- | | | |
|-----------|---|--------------------------|
| 11 | Cut one instruction down to three words or fewer.
Working memory is small, especially when nervous and underwater. Fewer words, faster action. | ☐ |
| 12 | Demonstrate it before you describe it.
A picture beats a paragraph. Show the shape, then add the word. | ☐ |
| 13 | Give one instruction at a time, not three stacked together.
'Big arms, kick hard, look down' is three lessons. Pick one. | ☐ |
| 14 | Pause three seconds after a question before jumping in.
Processing takes time. Silence isn't failure — it's the child thinking. | ☐ |
| 15 | Swap 'don't' for what you do want.
'Don't put your feet down' loads the brain with feet down. 'Float long' gives it somewhere to go. | ☐ |
| 16 | Use the same word for the same skill every time.
Consistency of language is consistency of learning. | ☐ |
| 17 | Check understanding by asking them to show you, not tell you.
'Show me a star float' reveals what 'yes I understand' hides. | ☐ |
| 18 | Add a hand signal to one verbal cue.
A visual cue cuts through noise, water in ears, and a busy mind. | ☐ |
| 19 | Lower your voice instead of raising it to get attention.
A loud pool gets louder when you compete with it. Drop your volume and watch them lean in. | ☐ |
| 20 | Name the next step before you ask for it.
A child who knows what's coming spends less energy on dread. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Where did saying less get you more? Note one instruction you'll keep short.

Inclusion & Neurodiversity

Neurodiversity is the natural variation in how brains work — e.g. autism (ASD) or ADHD. Small adjustments open the lesson up for everyone.

- | | | |
|-----------|--|--------------------------|
| 21 | Offer one hesitant learner a choice ('noodle or kickboard?').
Choice returns control to a child who feels they have none. Control lowers fear. | ☐ |
| 22 | Give one learner a clear 'first, then'.
Predictable structure is calming and lets them see the finish line. | ☐ |
| 23 | Warn a learner before any sudden change.
Sensory surprises can feel like a threat. A heads-up turns a shock into a plan. | ☐ |
| 24 | Let one learner watch a skill before being asked to try it.
Some children learn by observing first. Watching is participating. | ☐ |
| 25 | Offer a quieter spot away from the splashy group.
Sensory overload — too much input at once — shuts learning down. A calmer corner reopens it. | ☐ |
| 26 | Break one skill into the smallest possible step and mark it.
For a child who's stuck, 'face near the water' is a win worth celebrating. | ☐ |
| 27 | Accept a non-verbal yes — a nod, a thumbs up, a point.
Communication isn't only speech. Honour the answer in whatever form it arrives. | ☐ |
| 28 | Give one learner extra time without filling the silence.
Processing differences mean the answer is coming. Crowding it makes it slower. | ☐ |
| 29 | Notice a learner's special interest and use it ('let's be a shark').
A child's passion is a doorway. Walk through it instead of around it. | ☐ |
| 30 | Reflect on one thing you'd have wanted done for you as a learner.
The best inclusive practice starts with 'what did I need that I didn't get?' | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

What small adjustment made the biggest difference for one learner this week?

Safety & Awareness

Your eyes are the safety net. None of the rest matters if this slips.

- | | | |
|-----------|--|--------------------------|
| 31 | Scan the whole class every 30 seconds, even while teaching one child.
One child's lesson never costs another child your watch. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 32 | Count your learners in and count them out.
A headcount is two seconds. Not doing one is the gap incidents live in. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 33 | Position yourself so you can see the deep end and the gate.
Where you stand decides what you can prevent. Choose the sightline. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 34 | Check the water temperature from a child's perspective.
What's 'fine' to a warm adult can be cold-shock to a small body. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 35 | Clear one trip or slip hazard on the deck before class.
Thirty seconds now beats an incident report later. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 36 | Reset one learner's goggles or cap before they struggle.
Discomfort becomes distress becomes a refusal. Fix the small thing first. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 37 | Know exactly where your nearest rescue aid is right now.
In an emergency you won't go looking — you'll reach. Put it where your hand expects it. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 38 | Watch one learner's face for signs of cold or fatigue.
Blue lips and a wandering gaze talk before the child does. Read them early. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 39 | Run one 'what would I do if...' scenario in your head this shift.
Rehearsed responses are fast responses. The brain does what it has practised. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 40 | Brief a new learner on one pool rule in plain language.
Rules keep children safe only if they understand them. Drop the jargon. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

What's one safety habit that's now automatic that wasn't ten days ago?

Feedback & Encouragement

We over-correct and under-celebrate. These ten tip the ratio back the other way.

- | | | |
|-----------|---|--------------------------|
| 41 | Make one piece of praise specific enough to repeat.
<i>'Lovely straight legs' tells a child what to do again. 'Awesome' tells them nothing.</i> | ☐ |
| 42 | Praise the effort, not just the outcome, for one learner.
<i>Children praised for trying keep trying. Those praised only for winning quit when it's hard.</i> | ☐ |
| 43 | Give one learner a 'you couldn't do that last week' callback.
<i>Naming visible progress is rocket fuel. Be the keeper of their wins.</i> | ☐ |
| 44 | Replace 'no' with 'nearly — try it like this'.
<i>A near miss is a step, not a failure. Frame it as the rung it is.</i> | ☐ |
| 45 | Let one learner hear you tell their parent something they did well.
<i>Praise overheard hits twice as hard as praise delivered.</i> | ☐ |
| 46 | Give one learner a number to chase ('three big arms').
<i>A concrete target turns vague effort into a game they can win.</i> | ☐ |
| 47 | Catch one learner doing the right thing and stop to mark it.
<i>We notice mistakes by reflex. Make a point of catching the good.</i> | ☐ |
| 48 | Use the feedback sandwich only when it's genuine, not formulaic.
<i>Children smell a script. Mean the praise or skip it.</i> | ☐ |
| 49 | Ask one learner what they thought went well.
<i>Self-assessment builds a learner who can coach themselves when you're not there.</i> | ☐ |
| 50 | End one correction with belief ('you've got this, I've seen it').
<i>Correction plus confidence is teaching. Correction alone is just criticism.</i> | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Whose face lit up at your feedback this week? What exactly did you say?

Lesson Craft & Technique

Learners learn by doing, not by listening to you. Sharpen the craft that gets them moving.

- | | | |
|-----------|--|--------------------------|
| 51 | Plan the first 60 seconds of one lesson before you teach it.
A strong start sets the whole tone. Don't improvise the opening. | ☐ |
| 52 | Build one lesson around a single clear objective.
A lesson that tries to fix everything fixes nothing. Pick the one thing. | ☐ |
| 53 | Add one game that secretly drills the skill you're teaching.
Children repeat for fun what they'd refuse as a drill. Hide the broccoli. | ☐ |
| 54 | Reduce the talking-to-swimming ratio in one class.
More water time, fewer speeches. Doing is where the learning lives. | ☐ |
| 55 | Use the pool edge, steps or wall as a teaching tool.
The environment is equipment. A wall push teaches streamline for free. | ☐ |
| 56 | Isolate one part of a stroke before joining it to the whole.
Whole-part-whole works: break it down, polish the piece, put it back. | ☐ |
| 57 | Change a drill that isn't working rather than repeating it louder.
If it didn't land in three goes, the problem is the drill, not the child. | ☐ |
| 58 | Give one learner a slightly harder challenge to stretch them.
The child who's coasting is the child who's bored. Raise the bar a notch. | ☐ |
| 59 | Use a clear visual target for one skill.
A point to reach pulls better technique than an instruction about the body. | ☐ |
| 60 | Finish one skill on a success, even an easy one.
Ending on a win wires the brain to come back willing. Never end on the failed rep. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Which change to a lesson or drill worked best? How will you reuse it?

The Environment

The best teachers shape the space on purpose. Decide the environment; don't inherit it.

- | | | |
|-------|---|--------------------------|
| 61 | Look at your teaching space from the child's eye level once.
The glare, the depth, the echo — it's a different pool from down there. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 62 | Reduce one source of background noise or distraction.
Every extra input competes with your voice. Quiet the room, sharpen the lesson. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 63 | Set up your equipment before learners arrive, not during.
Fumbling for a kickboard is dead time and lost attention. Be ready. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 64 | Use the warmest, calmest corner for your most nervous learner.
Place the right child in the right water. Environment can do half your job. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 65 | Check the glare and stand to spare their eyes.
A child squinting into the sun can't watch your demo. Move so they can. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 66 | Make one transition between activities smoother and quicker.
Chaos lives in the gaps. Tighten the changeovers and behaviour improves. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 67 | Give one nervous learner a consistent 'home base' spot.
A known, safe place to return to lets a child venture further from it. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 68 | Remove one piece of clutter from your teaching zone.
A tidy space is a calm space — less to trip on, less to fixate on. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 69 | Notice the water depth relative to one small learner's height.
'Chest deep' for you is 'over my head' for them. Match the depth to the child. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 70 | Use temperature, light or quiet as a tool, not an accident.
Shape the environment on purpose. Decide it; don't inherit it. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

What did you notice from the learner's eye level that you'd never seen before?

Parents & Families

Parents fund, ferry and reinforce. Recruit them as partners and your 30 minutes a week multiply.

- 71

Tell one parent something specific their child achieved today.

Parents fund and ferry — pay them back in genuine, specific progress.

☐
- 72

Explain the ‘why’ behind one drill to a watching parent.

A parent who understands the plan starts reinforcing it at home.

☐
- 73

Give one parent a simple thing to practise (or not) at home.

You have 30 minutes a week; they have the bath every night. Recruit them.

☐
- 74

Reassure one anxious parent about their child’s pace.

Comparison is the thief of a parent’s joy. Reset the timeline kindly.

☐
- 75

Invite one parent’s insight (‘what helps them settle at home?’).

Parents are the experts on their child. Ask, and you’ll teach better.

☐
- 76

Manage one expectation honestly before it becomes a complaint.

A hard truth told early and warmly beats a disappointment found late.

☐
- 77

Acknowledge one parent’s effort getting their child there.

Wet towels, tantrums, the drive — showing up is work. Notice it.

☐
- 78

Use plain language, not swim-teacher jargon, with one family.

‘Streamline’ and ‘LTS levels’ mean nothing to most parents. Translate.

☐
- 79

Thank one parent for trusting you with their child.

It’s a big thing to hand over a frightened child. Honour the trust out loud.

☐
- 80

Help one family see the next milestone, not just today’s hurdle.

Parents stay the course when they can see the road ahead.

☐

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Which parent conversation shifted from worry to partnership? What did it?

Looking After Yourself

You can't pour from an empty cup. A well-resourced teacher is a better teacher.

- | | | |
|----|--|--------------------------|
| 81 | Drink water and actually take your break today.
A dehydrated, skipped-break teacher is a short-fused one. Look after the instrument. | ☐ |
| 82 | Reset between classes with three slow breaths.
A twenty-second reset stops the last hard lesson bleeding into the next child. | ☐ |
| 83 | Notice one thing you did well this shift, not just what you'd fix.
You coach children to celebrate small wins. Do it for yourself. | ☐ |
| 84 | Protect your voice — use signals and demos to talk less.
Your voice is a tool you can't replace mid-season. Spend it wisely. | ☐ |
| 85 | Ask a colleague one question instead of struggling alone.
The best teachers are the most curious, not the most self-sufficient. | ☐ |
| 86 | Leave one small thing at work when you clock off.
Carrying every lesson home burns you out. Put one down at the gate. | ☐ |
| 87 | Stretch or move for two minutes before your shift.
A warm, loose body teaches with more energy and fewer aches. | ☐ |
| 88 | Swap one 'I'm so tired' for one 'this child made my day'.
What you rehearse in the staffroom is what you'll feel on deck. | ☐ |
| 89 | Set one small professional goal for this week.
Growth is a habit, not an event. A tiny weekly aim keeps the engine running. | ☐ |
| 90 | Forgive yourself for one lesson that didn't go to plan.
Every great teacher has bad days. Learn the lesson, drop the guilt. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

What's one thing you'll keep doing to look after yourself on deck?

Leadership & Growth

You set the culture you complain about. Finish by becoming the teacher who lifts the others.

- | | | |
|------------|---|--------------------------|
| 91 | Watch a colleague teach for five minutes and steal one idea.
The best professional development is on your own deck. Borrow shamelessly. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 92 | Offer one newer teacher a specific, kind piece of encouragement.
Be the senior you wish you'd had. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 93 | Ask one learner or parent for feedback and actually listen.
The people you serve see your blind spots. Invite the mirror. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 94 | Write down one thing that worked so you don't lose it.
A teacher's best ideas die unrecorded. Keep a running list. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 95 | Share one of your own tricks with the team this week.
Knowledge hoarded is knowledge wasted. A team that shares lifts everyone. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 96 | Try one thing you've been avoiding because it's uncomfortable.
Growth lives one step past comfortable. Take the step today. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 97 | Reflect on one learner who challenged you and what they taught you.
Your hardest learners are your best teachers. Thank them by learning. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 98 | Let a junior teacher run one skill while you support.
Trust given is confidence built. Hand over the reins for two minutes. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 99 | Name one value you want your teaching to stand for.
Technique fades; character is what they remember. | ☐ |
| <hr/> | | |
| 100 | Look back at Day 1 and notice how far you've come.
A hundred 1% changes look like everything in hindsight. That's the whole point. | ☐ |

REFLECT ON THIS THEME

Look back at Day 1. What can you do now that you couldn't then?

Day 100 — and beyond

If you've made it here, you didn't become a better teacher in one heroic leap. You did it the only way that lasts — one small, deliberate change at a time.

The challenge ends at Day 100, but the habit doesn't have to. Pick the theme you most want to keep growing, and start the loop again.

Better isn't a destination you arrive at. It's a direction you keep choosing — 1% at a time.

For team rollout, printed booklets or tailored professional development for your swim school:

connor@aquatictrainingsolutionsaustralia.com.au · Aquatic Training Solutions Australia